

CHRISTENDOM COLLEGE

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The History of Western Political Thought

Lecture 3: The Origins of Modern Political Thought: Niccolò Machiavelli and "The Prince"

Introduction

Greetings from Christendom College. My name is Dr. Joseph Bruto. I am an Assistant Professor of Political Science here at Christendom and the Chairman of the Political Science Department. I'd like to welcome you to this lecture on the origins of modern political thought, Niccolò Machiavelli and the Prince. In the previous lectures, we were speaking of political thought as exemplified in the ancient and medieval worlds. And in spite of the differences between the political thought of Aristotle from the ancient Greek world and St. Thomas Aquinas from the medieval Christian world, we also noted many ways in which the thought of those two great philosophers shared much in common. In this lecture, I am going to begin by speaking of the transition out of the medieval world and into what we call modern political philosophy. Now, it is hard for a philosopher or even a historian to identify precisely when this transition occurs. As I often tell my students, it's not as if someone snapped his fingers one day and we woke up in the modern world. It's probably most accurate to understand this transition out of the medieval world and into the period that we call modernity as having occurred over, in fact, a couple of centuries. Beginning roughly, we might say, in the early 1400s and extending for a few centuries thereafter. Now thankfully, for my purposes, I'm not nearly as concerned with the timeline as I am with the features that mark this transition out of the ancient and medieval world view and into what I will call the modern world view.

Transition from Medieval to Modern Political Philosophy

So what features mark this transition? Well, there are a number of features that I could point to, but for my purposes, I would like to emphasize just one. This transition out of the ancient and medieval world and into modern political philosophy occurs when Aristotelian philosophy comes to be roundly rejected. When Aristotle first published his writings in the fourth century BC, they basically set the stage for all subsequent work in philosophy for most of the next 2000 years. This does not mean that all of the philosophers working in

that period necessarily embraced or endorsed what Aristotle had to say, but it did mean that Aristotle's writings and teachings set the framework for all work in philosophy.

As we transition to the modern period, this becomes less and less the case. And when I refer to a rejection of Aristotelian philosophy, I really do mean a wholesale rejection, a rejection of his views on biology, a rejection of his views on economy, a rejection of his views on metaphysics. But for my purposes, I'm going to be concerned with the rejection of Aristotle's views on ethics and politics, and in particular, the rejection of Aristotle's understanding of what we have been calling teleology. So just to remind you, teleology is the view that man has a fixed nature and end. That everything he does, he does for a reason, and there is one ultimate reason or purpose for his acting and choosing, some one ultimate end, some one highest human good. As we transition into the modern period and come to see the rejection of teleology, this brings with it the rejection of the idea that man has a fixed end at all. Some philosophers beginning in this period simply think that human beings, like other things in the cosmos, are a mere collection of atoms and molecules bumping into one another in a completely random manner and that what we take to be human ends and purposes are nothing but illusions. We comfort ourselves, these philosophers might say, with the idea that we can control our lives, with the idea that we in fact possess free will, but really everything that happens in the universe and by extension, everything that happens in human life is in fact random and nothing ultimately is up to us. Now it's important to note that not all modern philosophers embrace that view. Some of them embrace a slightly less extreme version of that view and this is the version that the philosopher Nikko Omaki of Elle is going to be concerned with. On this less extreme view, philosophy acknowledges that an individual human being might have an end or purpose to his life, but he also claims that that end or purpose is not necessarily the same for all human beings. Another way of thinking of this is that the end or purpose of my life just ends up being whatever I want it to be. If I want to live my life in a particular way, I give it one purpose. If you would like to live your life in a different way, you give it a different purpose and there isn't really anything that sort of unifies those purposes or holds them together. So we may in summary speak of purpose within an individual human life, but there isn't necessarily anything shared about human purposes across any number of human lives. Now students are often interested in what causes this transition out of the ancient and medieval world away from Aristotelian philosophy and into the modern world. Now answering that question could occupy an entire lecture in itself, but I would just like to point to a few causes, three of them in fact. One would be the Protestant Reformation, a second, the scientific revolution, and a third, the Enlightenment movement in philosophy. The Protestant Reformation is important here because a particular strand of it, namely a strand that sort of owes its origins to the philosopher and theologian John Calvin, came to understand human beings as so fundamentally fallen and corrupt that human reason was

not capable of discovering ends or purposes. If you recall our first lecture on Aristotle, we noted the ways in which rationality and rational activity were so important and fundamental to Aristotle's understanding of what a human being is. If you adopt a Protestant or specifically Calvinist view that reason has become so corrupted by sin and error, it is unsurprising that much of the rest of Aristotelian philosophy would fall with it. Similarly, the scientific revolution began to believe that it understood the universe in a disordered way. Certain scientists and certain philosophers of this period looked at the cosmos and believed that they did not find their order and purpose, but instead randomness and chaos. And this led them very quickly to reject Aristotle's scheme of human life and of the political community and ultimately of the cosmos itself as being ordered and filled with purpose. All of these movements fundamentally embrace the idea that man has complete control over himself in the world and can make of human nature and of the world whatever he desires. So with that brief introduction to modern philosophy out of the way,

The Prince

I would now like to consider the political philosophy of Niccolo Machiavelli, one of the great Italian political philosophers of this period. Machiavelli lives from 1469 to 1527. And he is considered by most to be the first truly modern political philosopher. We think of Machiavelli as a philosopher and in this lecture, I am going to consider him as such. But we must understand that Machiavelli would have been seen in his own time as more than that. Machiavelli, yes, writes works of philosophy, but he also writes works of history and literature. He is what we might call a man of letters. But his most famous work and the work that I am going to consider in the time that I have remaining comes to us with the simple title, *The Prince*. Now we know, just by way of background, that this work was composed no later than the year 1513. But we also know that the work was not published in Machiavelli's lifetime. The first published edition of *The Prince* that we can find dates back to about 1533 years after Machiavelli's death. There's much speculation as to why it is that Machiavelli did not publish this treatise in his lifetime. But as you will see very shortly, the fundamentally different and controversial nature of it may account for the decision to wait on publication. Now this treatise of Machiavelli's is comparatively speaking short. In most English editions, it runs to little over a hundred pages. And it is written as a treatise, Machiavelli tells us explicitly, to offer advice to princes. Now, I want to clear up one potential confusion in terminology. Machiavelli speaks in the work, and I will speak in the rest of this lecture of princes. But understand that that term can be used as a substitute for political rulers more generally and more generically. So this is not narrow advice that Machiavelli is offering only to those persons who have princely titles, but rather to anyone who might be or who might find himself to be a political ruler. Now, as I previously

mentioned, many aspects of this work were considered quite scandalous when they were first published in the mid 16th century, and many of those aspects remain scandalous today. Nonetheless, as I tell my students, it is important, I think, to continue to read and to study Machiavelli's writings because of how influential they have been on the shaping of modern understandings of politics. We may not like what Machiavelli has to say, but we cannot deny his enduring influence. And so, if we are going to work to criticize or to critique some of his views, we need to be able to understand those views as Machiavelli presents them. I would now like to turn to a consideration of the text of Machiavelli's "The Prince." And before I get into the details of the work, I would like to consider some of the important themes of the work that Machiavelli is going to raise. And here I'm gonna highlight two. As you will see, Machiavelli likes contrasts and he likes putting things in pairs. So two important themes that I often draw my students' attention to are the themes of the old versus the new, and an obviously related theme of appearance versus reality. Now, where do we see examples of these themes in Machiavelli's treatise? So I'm gonna point to one here at the outset and I will highlight a few others later. If you were to have picked up a copy of "The Prince" when it was first published, and if you were to turn to the table of contents, you would have encountered a listing of chapter titles. Now, one thing you would have noticed about those chapter titles when you opened up your copy was that they were written in Latin. And when you picked up this treatise in the mid-16th century, this would not have surprised you. Even though we are transitioning into the modern world, Latin at this time is still the language of educated discourse, and seeing the chapter titles of a philosophical treatise written in Latin would have been wholly unsurprising. And yet, if you were to flip further and actually examine the text of the various chapters of the treatise itself, you may in fact have been surprised, because what you would discover when flipping to the text of the chapters themselves is that that text was written in Italian, written in the vernacular, not a common practice for philosophical treatises written in this period. So even baked into the very language of the text, we can see an example of this dichotomy between old and new.

You look at the chapter titles written in Latin and you expect one thing and you flip to the text and you encounter something new, something unexpected, something very different. Now, in addition to these themes of old versus new and appearance versus reality, it's also important to note some of the clever ways in which Machiavelli operates in his writing.

If you are to pick up and read this treatise, you would be struck by the fact that Machiavelli makes use of a lot of words and concepts that would have been familiar to you from your study of Aristotle. You'll see Machiavelli speak often of virtue and goodness and fortune, all concepts that you can find discussed at length in Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*. But it

doesn't take much close examination to figure out that Machiavelli is using these terms in ways vastly different from that in which Aristotle would have used them.

Conflicting Ideas of Virtue

So let me take just one example, maybe the most important and that has to do with the concept of virtue. In the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle teaches us that virtues are habits that perfect our character. Courage, for example, is a virtue that helps to perfect our character in the face of danger or death. Aristotle understands these virtues as what he calls a mean or a middle point between two extremes. Courage, for example, is the mean or the middle point between cowardice on the one extreme or rashness or boldness on the other extreme. But most importantly, for Aristotle, a virtue is something that works to perfect our character. When we examine by contrast Machiavelli's understanding of virtue, we see quickly that he uses that term very differently.

What is a virtue for Machiavelli? Well, it is simply a synonym for skill, cleverness, craftiness or cunning in achieving whatever end you wish to achieve. In other words, virtue for Machiavelli has nothing to do or at least nothing necessarily to do with perfecting one's character with making one a better person, but it is simply a kind of tool, a kind of skill that you as an individual or a political leader can make use of in the pursuit of whatever goals he may have in mind. Now, while we're talking about Machiavelli's rejection of Aristotle in these ways, it won't surprise you to learn that Machiavelli does not articulate a specific view of what he understands, the *telos* or end or ultimate good of the human being to be. In so far as Machiavelli has such an understanding, he tells us that human life and in particular political rule and political leadership is all about getting power, maintaining power and being remembered for the way that you exercised your power after you are gone. So in some ways, the highest achievement of a human being for Machiavelli is to achieve glory for the way in which he used political power.

Now, let's turn to a more specific examination of the way in which Machiavelli undermines Aristotelian philosophy and applies his new understanding to particular political concepts and problems.

On the Subject of Cruelty

And I want to turn first, to a discussion that Machiavelli has early on in the prince about the subject of cruelty. Machiavelli begins one of his chapters by asking the following question. Is it appropriate for a prince to use cruelty to attain power? Obviously on the older Aristotelian understanding, the answer to this question would be no. It is not good for a human being or for the development of his character to engage in cruel or deceitful means

to attain his goals. Machiavelli, perhaps unsurprisingly, does not agree. Machiavelli says that it is acceptable for a prince to use cruelty to attain power, provided that in his words, the prince or the political leader uses cruelty well.

And we might ask ourselves, what does it mean to use cruelty well? And Machiavelli has a definition for us. He says that a political leader who uses cruelty well is a leader who uses cruelty all at once and yet never returns to the exercise of cruelty again. And in illustrating this point, he gives us an historical example. He gives us the example of a man by the name of Cesare Borgia. Cesare Borgia was in the process of acquiring various territories on the Italian peninsula. And at the time of Machiavelli's story, Cesare had acquired what is known and what was then known as the Romagna region. Now when Cesare acquires the territory and surveys it and takes account of the people and their government there, he understands that this people and this territory has been badly managed. And he knows that he needs to do something about it if he would like to consolidate his power. So Machiavelli asks, what are his options? Well, one option would be to sort of go there himself and sort of put the place in order. But Cesare recognizes, according to Machiavelli, that this could bring resentment amongst the people who would not take kindly to their government and their way of life being changed or upended. So what does Cesare choose to do instead? Well, he chooses to send another man there to do his dirty work, as it were. He sends this emissary to sort of go in and correct the problems that he notes in this region. Unsurprisingly, this emissary is resented by the people of Romagna for the changes that he has introduced, changes that they do not like. So after this transformation has taken place, what does Cesare do? Well, he shows up in the Romagna region himself. And he takes this emissary who he had sent to clean up the province according to his orders. And he literally cuts him in half and displays his body in the piazza for all to see. And he looks to the people and says to them, "In a sarcastic way, I'm so sorry for all of the cruelty that was done to you. That of course did not happen on my order. This is why I have ordered the execution of this man. And here I am to sort of be your great political savior. As horrifying as this story may sound to us, Machiavelli considers this to be an example of cruelty well used. And I don't think it takes much for us to understand how vastly different this understanding of politics is from that espoused by Aristotle or Aquinas. There is no concept here of what we have previously called the political common good. In fact, when Machiavelli refers to good or goodness at all, he almost never makes reference to it with respect to the political community and its end or its organization. But instead refers to good or goodness, simply as that which is of most benefit to the ruler. So before I wrap up, I would like to give you one extended passage from Machiavelli in his own words that really highlights the way in which he understands what he is doing as different from what has come before. So here I quote, "It remains now to see what the modes and the government "of a prince should be with subjects and with friends. "And because I know that many have

written of this, "I fear that in writing of it again, "I may be held presumptuous, "especially since in disputing this matter, "I depart from the orders of others. "But since my intent is to write something useful "to whoever understands it, "it has appeared to me more fitting "to go directly to the effectual truth of the thing "than to the imagination of it. "And many have imagined republics and principalities "that have never been seen or known to exist in truth. "For it is so far from how one lives "to how one should live that he who lets go "of what is done for what should be done "learns his ruin rather than his preservation. "For a man who wants to make a profession of good "in all regards must come to ruin among so many "who are not good.

"Hence, it is necessary to a prince "if he wants to maintain himself to learn, "to be able, not to be good. "This is one of the most famous passages "in all of Machiavelli's writings,

Machiavelli as Opposed to his Predecessors

"and I want to conclude by examining "a number of the things that Machiavelli says here. "First, note the contrast that Machiavelli makes "between himself and those who have come before him. "He criticizes his predecessors for writing "of what he calls imagined republics and principalities. "In other words, they have their head in the clouds. "They are interested in what is ideal or perfect "or theoretically best." Machiavelli rejects that understanding of politics because he takes it to not be useful. As he says, he wants to go directly to the effectual truth of the thing. He is less concerned with what is ideal and perfect and more concerned with what is useful and effective. Notice also Machiavelli says that he's not concerned with how an individual human being ought to live, but rather with what an individual human being needs to do to preserve and to protect himself. As he says, one who lives according to how one ought to live rather than according to how one should actually live learns his ruin rather than his preservation. What is important is what is necessary to maintain one's life, one's power, and one's interests in the world, whether that be what is theoretically best or not. And this issues in the end of that quotation, the very famous and somewhat jarring admonition that one must learn to be able not to be good.

Conclusion

So in summary, I have introduced to you the beginning of a movement called modern political philosophy which embraces a wholly new conception of what human nature and politics is. It does not understand human beings as having a fixed end. Rather, it understands human beings as being motivated principally by power and glory, especially in the political realm. This of course is a new conception of politics. We see here no discussion

of the common good or what is best for the people as a whole. Instead, the focus is on the ruler and what is best for him in the sense of coming to power and maintaining it.

We see Machiavelli redefine older concepts like virtue and goodness. These concepts are now not understood as Aristotle or Aquinas would have understood them, but they are now put to the use of talking about what benefits an individual. Human life and by extension politics is not guided by any external or objective standard.

It is simply a matter of fulfilling human desire and doing what one can to achieve those desires.

Study Questions

1. Which was NOT a feature of the transition from medieval to modern philosophy?

- A) The idea that man's reason is too corrupted to know absolute truth
- B) The rediscovery and newfound appreciation of the works of Aristotle
- C) The rejection of the idea that man has a fixed end
- D) The understanding of the universe as disordered

2. In its original publication, the chapter titles of *The Prince* were in Latin, but the text itself was written in the Italian vernacular. What theme common to Machiavelli's works does this speak to?

- A) The dichotomy between the old and new
- B) Machiavelli's desire to appeal to both educated and common folk
- C) The theme of appearance versus reality
- D) Machiavelli's habit of surprising and scandalizing his readers

3. Which of the following best describes Machiavelli's understanding of virtue?

- A) Habits that perfect our character
- B) The excellent performance of a thing's function
- C) Cunning in achieving any desired end
- D) The mean between two extremes

4. According to Machiavelli, a political leader uses cruelty well when:

- A) He uses it as his sole means of obtaining power
- B) It is used only when the leader's life is endangered
- C) He uses it for the sake of the common good
- D) It is used all at once, and never again